A Padyatra to Reclaim Hope

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It seemed like just another ordinary day in my small village in Kerala. Given it was August 2020, the conversation naturally revolved around the monsoon rains. For Malayalees, politics is an ever-present thread woven into the very fabric of daily life, and even the rains cannot escape its embrace. As the predictions suggested heavy rains, we huddled together with a sense of foreboding creeping in. It has been like this since the great floods of 2017.

This unease, however, was not limited to the weather, for it mirrored a broader sentiment that had been growing since the outcome of the 2019 national elections. My understanding of India had increasingly become tinged with a feeling of helplessness. Although I had roots in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, these regions were sanctuaries of hope amid a landscape choked with hate. We were like the Gauls resisting the Roman Empire, but in the grand tapestry of the nation, this resistance seemed insignificant.

The past few years had been fraught with challenges—the Covid-19 pandemic, the heart-wrenching sight of millions left stranded on the streets because of unplanned lockdowns, millions of lives (including many I work with) battered by fiscal policies since 2014, the disturbing surge in hate attacks against non-Hindus, cases of organized lynchings reminiscent of the Ku Klux Klan, and attacks on students, liberal activists, cultural leaders and even journalists. The three contentious farm laws gave rise to massive farmer protests, with hundreds of thousands converging on New Delhi, staying put for an unprecedented 500 days, with many annadatas sacrificing their lives. Divisions have insidiously infiltrated our society, in every town